

Glossary — the program's compendium

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How the glossary works

Every term the program uses on purpose is here once, in plain words, with the unit where a learner first meets it, the terms it connects to, and — for the briefer lane — one line on how to use it with a designer; version 1 holds the program's core vocabulary and F1's, about ninety terms, and grows with each module through the factory.

Rules for entries

1. A term enters the glossary when a unit introduces it; it is never used in unit copy before its unit.
2. One term per idea; synonyms are listed as "also called", never used interchangeably.
3. Meanings are one or two sentences, written for someone who has not studied design.
4. "Met in" is the first unit; later uses are found through the Atlas and the unit register, not listed here.
5. "Say it to a designer" appears where a briefer would use the idea in a meeting or a brief.
6. In the app, every term is a link wherever it appears; "Related" terms are links too, which is what makes this a compendium rather than a list.

The program and the method

Term	Meaning	Met in	Related	Say it to a designer
Artifact	The one thing every learner builds through the program: their Concept DNA and what attaches to it	O1.3	Concept DNA, sources record	—

Term	Meaning	Met in	Related	Say it to a designer
Lane	The way a learner applies each unit: the maker lane produces; the briefer lane writes briefs and judges work	O1.3	Apply step, route	—
Depth	How far into a module a learner goes: Orientation (the idea), Practice (the usable core), Mastery (the full studio and defence)	O1.3	Route, slice	—
Route	A default path through the depths for a kind of learner: Maker, Briefer, Founder, Student	O1.3	Lane, persona	—
Opening move	How a unit begins, chosen for what its knowledge needs: lab, object, story, problem, prediction, argument, artifact, partner, data or making first	Every unit	Unit	—
Apply step	The part of a unit where the learner uses the idea on their own world	Every unit	Lane	—

Term	Meaning	Met in	Related	Say it to a designer
Thread	A concern that recurs across the program and must progress, not repeat: planetary weight, handover, attribution, accessibility, writing, AI collaboration	F1 (attribution)	Checkpoint	—
Partner voice	One of seven AI roles that question the learner's work without grading it: Mirror, Stranger, Client, Fabricator, CFO, Historian, Planet	O1.4	Historian, Stranger test	—
Seed world	A ready-made fictional world a learner can use when they have no project of their own	O1.3	Exemplar world	—
Concept DNA	The versioned set of rules from which anyone can build a world correctly: premise, rules, grammars, anti-DNA, tests, brief, history	O1.3; M2	Premise, grammar, Stranger test	"Here are the rules; show me what you would build from them."

Term	Meaning	Met in	Related	Say it to a designer
Premise	A world's proposition, stance, central contradiction, human scenario and non-goals	M1.9	Perimeter, stance	"What is this world for, and what will it never do?"
Perimeter	What a world enables, protects, resists, rejects and transforms	F5.1	Non-goal	"Tell me what this protects and what it refuses."
Non-goal	Something the world deliberately does not try to do	M1.12	Perimeter	"Which good ideas are we saying no to?"
Constant	A rule that never changes, whatever the product or medium	M2.4	Variable, threshold	"What must be true of everything we make?"
Variable	A rule that may flex to suit a product, place or audience	M2.4	Constant, threshold	"What can change from one piece to the next?"
Threshold	How far a variable may move before the world stops being itself	M2.4	Edge	"How far can this go before it isn't us?"

Term	Meaning	Met in	Related	Say it to a designer
Grammar	A family of rules for one dimension of a world: formal, material, construction, chromatic, spatial, atmospheric, sensory, behavioural, interaction, temporal, narrative or verbal	M2.6	Concept DNA	"Which grammars carry this brand, and which are open?"
Anti-DNA	What the world is incapable of being	M2.5	Non-goal	"What would make this unmistakably wrong?"
The four tests	Belongs, edge, failure, seductive-but-off: the four verdicts any piece can get against a world's rules	M2.2	Test set	"Is this on-brand, on the edge, off, or tempting but off?"
Seductive-but-off	A piece that is attractive and even excellent but breaks the world's rules	M2.2	The four tests	"I love it, but which rule does it break?"
Stranger test	Giving the rules to someone who has never met you (a person or the AI Stranger) and scoring how far their result drifts	M2.15	Drift, contributor brief	"Could a stranger build this from the brief alone?"

Term	Meaning	Met in	Related	Say it to a designer
Drift	How far a stranger's result moves from the world's rules; the measure of a weak rule	M2.15	Stranger test	—
Contributor brief	The Concept DNA rewritten as instructions for someone else to build from	M2.19	Brief	—
Anchor	The piece that establishes a world most fully; the one everything else refers to	M3.3	Hero, family	"Which piece carries the world if we can only make one?"
Hero, core, entry, experimental, supporting	The other roles a piece can play in a collection	M3.3	Anchor, collection	"Which role is this piece playing?"
Carrier	Where a world meets people: a shop, a site, a feed, a package, a person	M3.8	Touchpoint	"Where will people actually meet this?"
Adjacent translation	The same world expressed in a second medium, as a test of its rules	M4.3	Drift	—

History and culture

Term	Meaning	Met in	Related	Say it to a designer
Reading an object	Treating a made thing as a document of its material, the labour behind it, the trade that moved it and what it meant	F1.1	Autopsy, object biography	"What does this object tell us about who made it and why?"
Autopsy	F1's lab for reading an object layer by layer: material, labour, trade, meaning, and at Practice, technique	F1.1, F1.25	Reading an object	—
Canon	The set of works and makers a field treats as essential; always a choice made by someone	F1.3	Counter-history	"Whose canon are we drawing on here?"
Periodisation	Dividing time into named periods; the names carry assumptions about where history happened	F1.3	Calendar, canon	—
Counter-history	A history told from what the dominant account leaves out	F1.3	Canon, obscured labour	—
Design history and design studies	Two ways the field studies itself: the history of made things, and the study of designing as an activity	F1.3	—	—

Term	Meaning	Met in	Related	Say it to a designer
Recurrence	Something invented or developed independently in several places and times, such as writing, cities, metallurgy, weaving and printing	F1.5	Stimulus diffusion	—
Stimulus diffusion	Borrowing the idea of something without borrowing its form; one reading of how writing reached Egypt	F1.5	Recurrence	—
World of making	One of F1's regional chapters, read through a device (metallurgy, fibre, the workshop, cotton, routes, the guild, navigation) rather than a list	F1.6	Network	—
Network	A route system that moved objects, materials and skills: Silk Roads, Indian Ocean, trans-Saharan, Mediterranean, Atlantic, Pacific	F1.10, F1.13	Route, copy chain	—

Term	Meaning	Met in	Related	Say it to a designer
Copying and transfer	How forms, techniques and goods were imitated across places, from porcelain to chintz; the engine of exchange and the origin of licensing questions	F1.14	Adaptation, licence	"Is this a transfer we'd credit, or a copy we'd have to license?"
Exhibition as taxonomy	How world's fairs and catalogues sorted the world's making into categories, often by extracting it	F1.15	Appropriation	—
Commissioning regime	The system by which a brief is issued and paid for: patron, guild, merchant, industry, agency, platform	F1.17	Brief	"Which regime are we in, and who really holds the brief?"
Guild	An association of makers that set rules for training, quality and trade	F1.11, F1.17	Commissioning regime	—
Waqf	An Islamic charitable endowment that funded buildings and institutions, and so commissioned making	F1.10, F1.17	Commissioning regime	—
Karkhana	A Mughal court workshop producing goods for the ruler	F1.9, F1.17	Commissioning regime	—

Term	Meaning	Met in	Related	Say it to a designer
Obscured labour	The work of makers, technicians and communities whose names do not appear on the object	F1.23	Credit map	"Who made this that we are not naming?"
Credit map	F1's lab for pulling an object apart into everyone who contributed to it	F1.23	Attribution line	—
Object biography	The life of a thing from making through use, trade, ownership and display; also called the social life of things	F1.22a	Provenance	—
Provenance	The documented chain of an object's owners and holders	F1.24	Restitution	"Where has this object been, and how did it get here?"
Restitution	Returning objects to the communities or nations they were taken from	F1.24	Provenance	—
Operational sequence	A technique read as an ordered chain of gestures, tools, materials and knowledge; also called chaîne opératoire	F1.25	Technique, reconstruction	—
Reconstruction	Remaking a historical technique from a text or object to learn what the record does not say	F1.28a	Operational sequence	"How do we know it was made that way?"

Term	Meaning	Met in	Related	Say it to a designer
Vernacular intelligence	Knowledge carried in local practice, oral history, folktale and local ways of naming	F1.29	Living practice	—
Living practice	A making tradition still carried by people today; recorded in the Atlas as a Practice	F1.6–F1.12	Intangible heritage	"Is this tradition still practised, and by whom?"
Intangible heritage	Practices, skills and knowledge recognised as heritage, as distinct from objects; UNESCO keeps lists nominated by states	F1.3, F1.6	Living practice	—
Counterfactual history	A disciplined "what if": one changed fact, with consequences traced from sources	F1.30a	Scenario	—
Pluralism and decolonisation	Adding more regions to an existing story (pluralism) is different from letting other frames set the story (decolonisation)	F1.3	Canon	—

Rights, credit and protocol

Term	Meaning	Met in	Related	Say it to a designer
Reference	Pointing to a source openly as an influence	F1.2	Spectrum	"What are we referencing, and do we say so?"
Quotation	Reusing a recognisable part of a source, credited	F1.2	Spectrum	"Are we quoting this, and is it credited?"
Adaptation	Changing a source to fit a new use while keeping its identity	F1.2	Spectrum	—
Translation	Carrying a source into another medium, culture or language	F1.2	Adjacent translation	—
Appropriation	Taking from a culture without its consent, credit or benefit, especially where that culture has been harmed	F1.2	Harm, consultation	"Would the source community recognise this as theirs, and would they agree?"
Spectrum plane	F1's two-axis sort: reference to appropriation on one axis, harm to the source community on the other	F1.2	Appropriation	—
Attribution line	A short credit naming makers, sources and communities, generated from the sources record	F1.1	Credit map	"Put the attribution line in the deck."

Term	Meaning	Met in	Related	Say it to a designer
Consultation	Asking a source community before using what is theirs, and recording what was agreed, credited and given back	F1.26	CARE	"Who did we ask, and what did we agree?"
CARE principles	Collective benefit, Authority to control, Responsibility, Ethics: principles for handling Indigenous data and heritage	F1.26	Local Contexts	—
Local Contexts Notice	A placeholder label saying a record may carry community protocols, used until a community issues its own Label	F1.26	Label	—
Traditional Knowledge Label	A label issued by a community stating its permissions, attribution and protocols for a record	F1.26	Notice	—
Sensitivity flag	The world set's marker for sacred, ancestral, funerary or restricted material, excluded by default	F1.12, F1.26	CARE	—
Public domain	Free of copyright; usable by anyone	F1.3	CC0	"Is this public domain where we'll publish?"
CC0	A dedication placing a work in the public domain as far as law allows	F1.3	Public domain	—

Term	Meaning	Met in	Related	Say it to a designer
CC BY and NC	Creative Commons licences requiring credit (BY), and forbidding commercial use (NC)	F1.3	Licence	"Does this licence allow commercial use?"
Rights statement	One of twelve standard statements (RightsStatements.org) used by heritage institutions when a Creative Commons licence cannot apply	F1.3	Licence	—
Informed consent	Agreement given knowing the purpose, risks and uses, with the right to refuse and withdraw	F1.29	Narrator review	—
Narrator review	Letting the person recorded check, correct, restrict or withdraw what they said before it is shared	F1.29	Informed consent	—

The Atlas and its data

Term	Meaning	Met in	Related
Atlas	F1's graph of the history of making, with eleven views onto it; the place the module happens in	F1.1	View, ring
Node	Anything in the Atlas: an object, person, community, place, material, technique, movement, event, institution, text, route, idea or practice	F1.1	Relation

Term	Meaning	Met in	Related
Relation	A sourced link between two nodes, such as made by, copied from, traded along, commissioned by, influenced by	F1.13	Claim
Claim	A statement the Atlas makes, with its source and confidence	F1.5	Confidence
Confidence	How sure a claim is: documented, probable, contested, interpretive; contested claims show both readings	F1.5	Claim
Date range	Every date shown as earliest and latest, never as a single point unless it is one	F1.5	Uncertainty
Ring	Where a node's data comes from: Ring 1 is curated by the program; Ring 2 is linked context from open knowledge bases; Ring 3 is the open graph beyond, unreviewed	F1.3	Coverage
View	A way of seeing the Atlas: map, globe, timeline, occurrences, connections, movements, inventions, compare, story, lineage, calendars	F1.1	Lens
Lens	A filter across every view: labour and credit, material and extraction, gender, ritual and belief, commissioning, copying, provenance, body and access	F1.3	View
Coverage	How many licensed objects and practices the Atlas holds per world; where it is thin, the gap is shown and taught	F1.3	Bias of the record
Lineage	The learner's own layer of the Atlas, starting with their first object in F1.1	F1.1	Sources record
Sources record (SRC)	The learner's record of every source their world draws on, with rights, protocol and consultation; grows with depth	F1.1	Attribution line